UNIT 9

Envisioning a New Socio-Economic Order

Learning Objectives

To understand

- The economic situation in India at the time of Independence
- India as a socialist, democratic nation and what this signified
- Steps taken to improve agriculture and the rural economy
  a) Land reforms, and assessment of their effectiveness
  b) Technological development through the Green Revolution
  c) Rural development programmes
  d) Rural employment schemes
- Industrial Development
  a) Strategy and rationale of investment in heavy industry
  b) The role of the state and government controls on private industry and consumption through industrial regulation policies and legislation
  c) The role of the public sector
  d) Liberalisation and after
- Five Year Plans in India
- Education - The progress in literacy and expansion of school education
- Science and Technology: Growth of institutions of scientific research and technology in the country

Introduction

When India became independent in 1947, the economy of the country was very fragile and facing many problems. The level of poverty was very high. Nearly 80% of the population was living in rural areas, depending on agriculture for their livelihood. As the craft-based occupations had suffered during British rule, many skilled artisans had lost their livelihood. As a result, agriculture was overcrowded, and the per capita income from agriculture was very low. Agriculture was also characterised by semi-feudal relations between landowners and cultivators or peasants, who were often exploited by the land-owning classes.

The industrial sector had grown in the decades before Independence, but it was still quite small. The best known heavy industry was Tata Iron and Steel. Besides this, the main manufactures were cotton spinning and weaving, paper, chemicals, sugar, jute and cement. Engineering units produced machinery

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